

"THE FOCUS ON CHINA AS THE ROOT OF ALL TROUBLES IN NEIGHBOURING NATIONS IS MISPLACED. WE MUST EXAMINE IF WE HAVE BEEN AT FAULT"

–SHYAM SARAN *Former foreign secretary*

assassination of its founder and Hasina's father, Sheikh Mujibur Rehman, in 1975, the successor regimes were hostile to India despite New Delhi having played a substantial role in its war of independence. Khaleda Zia's two stints as premier, in 1991-96 and in 2001-06, saw her give shelter to anti-India elements, including Northeastern rebels. But India did have a dream run when Hasina came to power in her second stint from 2009 onwards. In the past decade or so, we have been able to settle our land dispute amicably, enabling the construction of major infrastructure projects, including transboundary connectivity between the two countries. Former foreign secretary Harsh Shringla, who had also served as high commissioner to Bangladesh from 2016-2019, points out, "We have made huge progress with Bangladesh in the past 15 years, more than what we did in the previous 35 years. It's important for us to work with the new dispensation there to continue that level of progress for ourselves and for the people of Bangladesh. Any instability or the lack of goodwill on the part of the new administration in Bangladesh could impact us in the Northeast and on issues such as transit and connectivity. At the same time, India would also have significant leverage over Bangladesh. Cooperation for mutual benefit is best for both neighbours."

THE SEAMS ARE SHOWING

What is worrying for India is that Bangladesh, rather than being an exception, is becoming the rule when it comes to relations with neighbours. The seams of the Modi government's Neighbourhood First policy are beginning to wear thin and the playbook India had adopted to deal with such crises looks dated. Arvind Gupta, a former deputy NSA and director of the Vivekananda International Foundation, says, "Our neighbourhood is imploding, and we can expect many more such events in the next few years. So, it is going to be our number one foreign policy priority. We must go back to the drawing board for our neighbourhood policy. Rather than the next 10 years, we should be thinking of what we should be doing in the next five years—a complete reinvention is required. We have to rethink to what extent we should reach out and the kind of people we cultivate." He points to another interesting aspect. "What we are missing out in most of these countries is our link with the youth," he says. "We are still dealing



with old-time politicians, while in most of these countries, the youth have taken over completely and, aided by social media, make a huge difference." Menon agrees and adds, "Let's face it, most Indians, including the establishment, especially in the past few years, have been acting as if we have outgrown the neighbourhood. We seem to be more interested in G20, the US and Russia. And our record in the neighbourhood is patchy and our commitment to them in terms of aid has diminished over time. You communalise domestic politics when your two biggest neighbours are Muslim. How do you deal with them, then?" Former foreign secretary Shyam Saran highlights a structural issue that needs to be sorted out. "We have been talking about the Neighbourhood First policy for quite some time, but do we have the established wherewithal and resources that must be deployed to give substance to it? Take human resource deployment, you can't have a ministry of external affairs that has only a couple of persons dealing with neighbouring countries."

The signs of Indian's loosening hold in the neighbourhood are everywhere. The recent regime change in the Maldives



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